EDTH | European Defense Tech Hub

How to Succeed at an EDTH Hackathon

A Short Guide for Hackers

Welcome to the European Defense Tech Hackathon!

We're running these weekend hackathons with one objective: build a real prototype — software, hardware, or both — to address an urgent security challenge.

The point of the weekend is not to win. The point is to put yourself in a position to keep building after everyone goes home, and ultimately to move towards deployment. The real winners are the teams still building in real life six months from now.

This guide is here to help you get there.

Forming Your Team

Form a team of 2–6 people on the first day (Friday). Friday is for arriving, team formation and getting everyone on the same page — Saturday and Sunday are for building.

You can work alone, but it's less fun, and we don't recommend it. If you're more than six people, split into two teams. You can work on your own project idea — but first, **validate it with a mentor** so it's not a pipe dream: Has it been tried before? Is there a simple insight for why it doesn't work? Better to find out on Friday than on Sunday!

What to Build

You have three paths, and all of them are fair game:

- **Your own idea** — as long as it fits the hackathon scope around defense tech.
- **Open problem statements** — we've prepared a set, sourced from our partners, sponsors, and the military, purely for your inspiration.
- **Sponsor challenges** — these come with dedicated mentors. If you have specific questions or need specific equipment, hit up the mentors associated with the challenge.

Whatever you pick, keep it useful. Build things that could actually be used in the real world — not demos that look clever and solve nothing.

You keep your IP. By default, everything shared at the hackathon is non-confidential.

Keep all projects and discussions within legal, ethical, and export-control boundaries. If anything feels unclear or sensitive, flag it to us so we can handle it properly.

Hardware & Equipment

We generally provide some hardware on-site: 3D printers, soldering stations, electronics, and more. Check the full list on our platform. If you need something very specific, let us know in advance — or grab it yourself from the local DIY shop.

Keep the Goal in Mind

The purpose of the hackathon is to build an actual prototype, using software and hardware, so you can get real feedback on your project and continue developing it afterward. Everything you do this weekend should serve that. **Our goal is to put you in a position to continue towards deployment.**

As you build, keep asking yourself the same questions a mentor would ask you: What problem are you really solving? Who is the user or stakeholder? Does this actually work in the real world? Is it novel, useful, and mass-producible?

Talk to Mentors

The single biggest mistake teams make is not talking to mentors.

These people volunteer their time and bring exactly the expertise you need to build a defense-tech startup: solving hard technical problems, military and field experience (how to actually use this stuff with frozen fingers in a trench), VC and fundraising, legal, manufacturing, and more.

These are people you wouldn't bump into over a coffee chat on the street. They are here for one reason — you. Walk up to the mentor table, ask questions, show them your work, and use their time. The strongest projects are almost always shaped by mentor feedback over the weekend.

One note on etiquette: mentors are here to help you build and learn, not to recruit or sell to you. If you want to follow up with someone after the event, that's great — and entirely up to you.

Your Submission

Submit a presentation (**PDF or PPTX**) by **Sunday noon.** This is the same deck you'll use when pitching on Sunday afternoon. **Start the file name with your team number** (e.g. "07_ProjectName.pdf").

Record your demo as a video, upload it somewhere (YouTube, Vimeo, Google Drive), and link it in the presentation — we'll click the link.

Need to update it? Just upload the new version — we discard the older one and use only the latest. **Do it before noon.** If you upload two minutes before your pitch, we can't guarantee we'll be able to pull the latest version from our server.

Your deck should cover four things:

- a) What problem are you solving?
- b) How are you solving it technically?
- c) How will this be deployed and mass-manufactured?
- d) What did you achieve during the hackathon?

Building a Deck That Lands

A good pitch tells a story. A simple frame that works: *"For [the person] doing [the activity], we built [your thing]. It makes their life easier, keeps them alive, helps them stop the enemy — and it costs less, does more, and weighs less."*

From there, walk the jury through your project in roughly this order — it maps cleanly onto how you'll be judged:

The problem — why this matters, and why now.

Feasibility — show it works and can actually be deployed in the field (e.g. in Zaporizhzhia oblast, at night).

Technical complexity — your approach, your algorithm, your iteration over the weekend.

Innovation — the key insights you found that others missed.

Business opportunity — how you make money.

Market size — how big the opportunity is.

Who you are — your unfair advantage is usually your people; say why this team can win.

Demo — not just slides: the video and photos of your progress over the weekend.

Three tips that consistently separate strong pitches from forgettable ones:

- Tell a story.
- Speak clearly and confidently.
- Close with a clear call to action: Who should approach you after the pitch?

The Pitch

- **3-minute pitch** + 1–2 questions from the jury.
- **Timing is strict.** We will cut you off.
- Pitches run one straight after another.
- After all the pitches (roughly 1.5–2 hours), the jury retreats to a separate room to choose the winners.

The Jury & How You're Judged

The jury comprises 5–7 people, each covering different angles — Ukrainian military, European military, industry, VC, technical experts, and so on. We pick them on Sunday morning, so there's no way to know who they are in advance, and no way to bribe them ;-)

Each juror scores you on seven criteria, from 0 (worst) to 10 (best):

Criterion	The question behind it
Relevant problem	Does this matter?
Feasibility of the solution	Does it work?
Originality / Innovation	Is this novel?
Mass-manufacturability	Is this scalable?
Business opportunity	Is there demand from customers?
Size of the opportunity	Are you addressing a big (multi-billion) market?
Pitch	Were the pitch and demo / MVP clear and relevant?

Your total score is the sum of all the jury scores. But here's the important part: the highest total does not automatically win. The scores guide the discussion — the jury debates who should win and draws on their own expertise to decide. After the hackathon, you'll receive the jury's actual feedback by email, anonymized.

Keep this in mind: winning is not the important part — continuing to build in real life is. The real winners emerge by building after the weekend ends, and we're here to help you do exactly that.

After the Hackathon

To submit your project and stay connected, fill in this form: forms.gle/yVn6Lrzn67bRqd2W6.

In it, tell us what support from EDTH would help move your idea forward, and how you'd like to connect with the EDTH Investor Network:

- Be featured in our monthly deal-flow update
- Participate in a virtual Demo Day
- Present your project at online showcase events

And by submitting, you'll be invited to join the **EDTH Unlimited** community with one year of free access to all EDTH events: Demo Days at EDTH Hackathons, webinars and exclusive online networking sessions, and our flagship annual conference, The New Defense Summit

Now go build something that matters!